Which acquisition channels bring profitable customers?

Executive summary · Fictional, synthetic data · 10,000 customers, Oct 2024 to Sep 2026 · all amounts in EUR

The bottom line

Every paid channel earns back its acquisition cost within six months, but **after credit losses only referral has a positive value per customer** (+54.49 over 12 months, not statistically proven; all customers together: -84.10). Affiliate has the best value before credit losses (251.54) and the worst after them (-490.95), because 24.1% of its loans default. Moving the budget as shown below improves the modelled quarter by about **40,700**, from -97,564 to -56,843. The quarter stays negative: most of the loss comes from loan losses, which marketing spend does not change.

What to do, in order of confidence

#	Action	Who and how much is at stake	Metric to track
1	**Stop Summer Reach style spend in paid social**	SO_Summer_Reach_2026 cost 365 per customer against a channel median of 62. It took 18,124, which is 24.5% of paid social spend.	Cost per customer by campaign; paid social at 158 in 2026-Q3
2	**Tighten credit rules for affiliate customers, before cutting affiliate spend**	Affiliate defaults on 24.1% of loans (others 6.5% to 12.5%) and holds 325,882 of the 841,904 credit loss. Early defaults reach 37.0% in affiliate students.	Default rate and credit loss by channel and segment
3	**Move money to referral in steps (up to +20%)**	Only channel with positive value after credit losses (+54.49), CAC 12.47. It is the smallest channel and may not scale.	Referral CAC and customers per month as spend rises
4	**Report channels with position-based credit next to the recorded channel**	The recorded channel gives paid social about 20% too much credit (CAC 65.59 becomes 81.87) and paid search about 22% too little (32.94 becomes 26.90).	Credit shift % and attributed CAC
5	**Find out why paid social customers verify but do not fund**	Only 52.4% of verified paid social customers fund, against 72% to 89% elsewhere.	Verified-to-funded rate by channel

What the data shows, by dashboard page

1. Executive	Blended CAC of the four paid channels is 37.49 and 12-month LTV is 184.18, but risk-adjusted LTV is -84.10. Payback is 2 months for referral, 3 for affiliate, 4 for paid search and 6 for paid social. The optimizer keeps spend at 15,058 against 28,603 at baseline.
2. Funnel	Paid social loses most after KYC (52.4% of verified customers fund). Affiliate loses at KYC itself (69.5% verify). Students (63.0%) and freelancers (67.2%) fund less often than salaried customers (80.4%).
3. Attribution and campaigns	Position-based credit gives paid social 244 fewer customers and paid search 347 more, and one campaign is wasteful: SO_Summer_Reach_2026. Every other campaign is within 0.86 to 1.25 times its channel median.
4. Credit risk	1,587 seasoned loans, 12.8% default, 841,904 credit loss. Affiliate is worst on every measure; grey cells in the report mark fewer than 50 loans and are not findings.
5. Budget scenarios	In all eight scenarios the reallocation beats the baseline, by 21,643 to 56,722. Budget +20% or -20% gives the same result, because the optimizer never wants to spend more where customers lose money.
6. KPI scorecard	Against six illustrative targets, referral meets all six, paid search four, affiliate three and paid social one. Paid social stays below the 75% verified-to-funded target in every quarter, and affiliate stays above the 10% default-rate target.

How much to trust this

The data is synthetic, so the channel ranking describes this simulation and not a real bank. Credit risk is the weakest part: default behaviour is an assumption and loans issued after 2026-03-31 carry no loss yet. The response curves are rough (24 monthly points each, R squared 0.25 to 0.70). The recommendation is a hypothesis and has not been tested. Next step: test it with a holdout before moving the whole budget.